



IIT ROORKEE



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CERTIFICATION COURSE

PUBLIC SPEAKING

Lecture 32: Group Discussion

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Group Discussion: An Exchange of Knowledge

Group Discussion is a form of public speaking which enables participants to exchange views, ideas, knowledge and experiences on a given issue, topic or question.

“Individual commitment to a group effort - that is what makes a team work, a company work, a society work, a civilization work.”

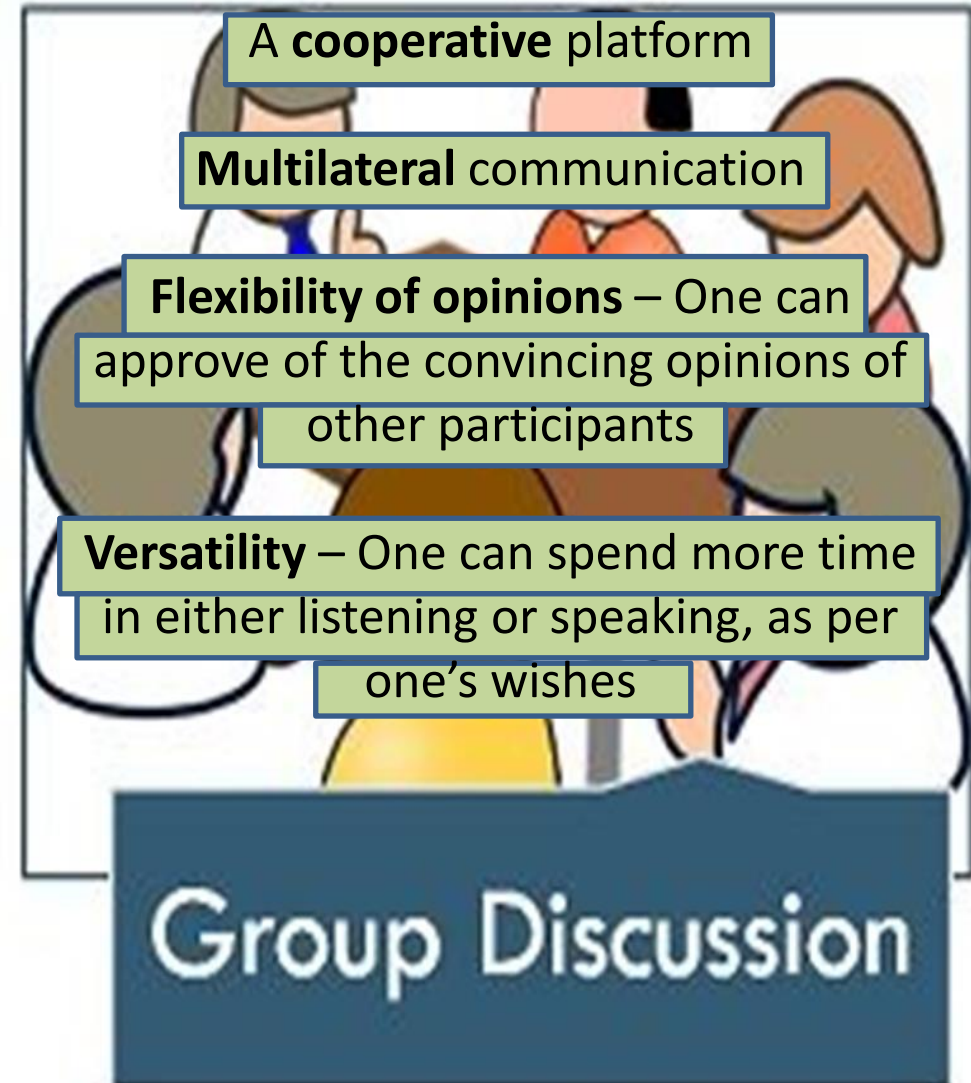
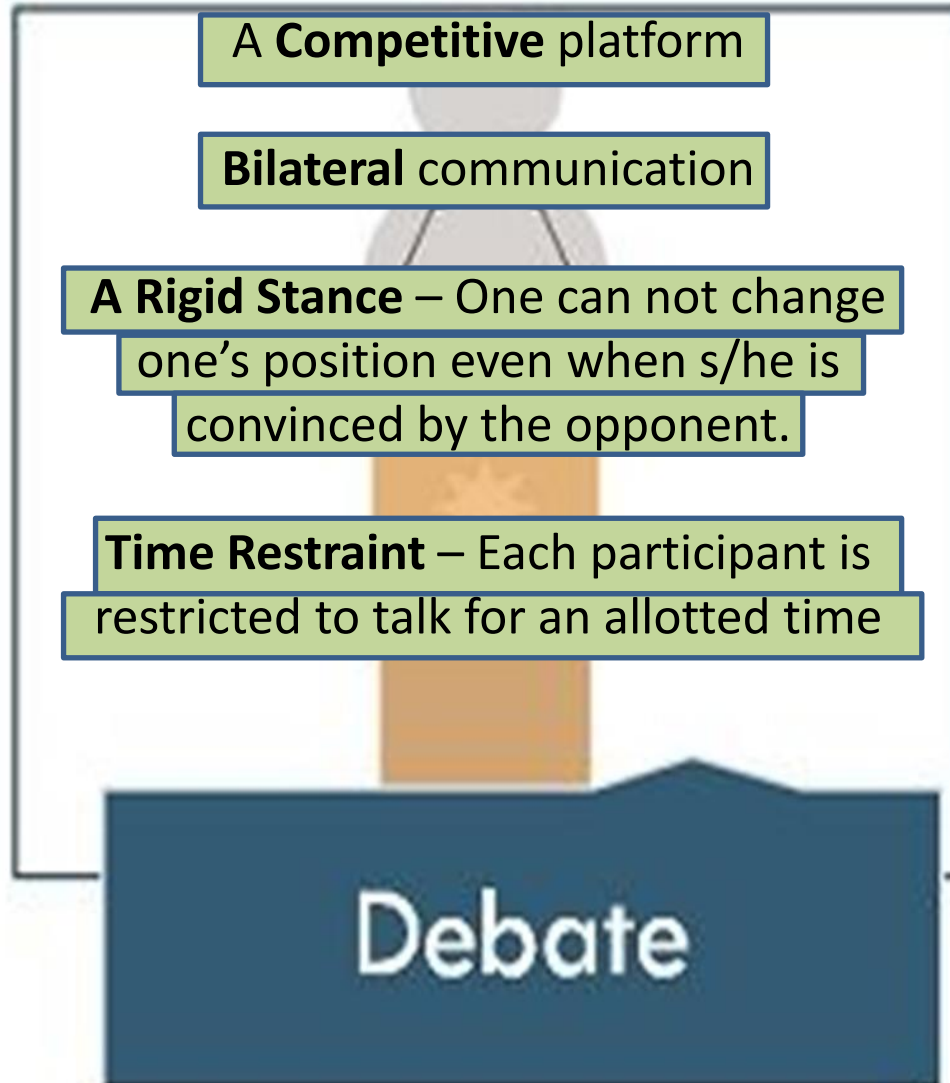
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Vince Lombardi

Aims of Group Discussion :

- ✓ Resolving an issue through discussion
- ✓ Exchanging information on a topic
- ✓ Evaluating students for academic purposes
- ✓ Assessing a candidate's skill during a job interview
- ✓ Measuring communication and Decision- making skills



Debate versus Group Discussion



Characteristics of Group Discussion

- ❖ A dialogic learning process
- ❖ Cooperative , not competitive
- ❖ Sharing thoughts, opinions, views
- ❖ Digging new insights
- ❖ Opportunity for every member to speak
- ❖ Unstructured
- ❖ More resources
- ❖ Flexibility

Group Discussion: Popular Techniques

❑ **Brainstorming Technique:**

- The participants need to physically assemble round a table.
- The problem is stated and clearly comprehended by all.
- Suggestions, alternative views, and criticisms are forwarded by the members.
- The ideas are analysed in detail within the spatial set up.

❑ **Nominal Group Technique:**

- Each member operates independently
- S/he understand the problem and writes his/her ideas without any discussion

Contd...

- Thereafter, each member is required to propose his/her outlook.
- Lastly, discussion takes place for reaching the consensus.
- Decision is taken on the basis of highest aggregate ranking.

□ Delphi Technique:

- Similar to Nominal Group technique, but physical presence of members is not required.
- Ideas are collected through well-curated questionnaires.
- Every member receives a copy of the results.
- Decision is arrived at by analysis of the responses of the members.

Steps to a Systematic Group Discussion

1. Introducing the Topic:

- The topic and the duration of GD is announced by the chairperson
- 2-3 minutes are allowed for a silent contemplation on the topic
- Thereafter, the discussion rolls on.
- An example of opening statement: *"Hello everybody! Today we are here to discuss a much-talked about issue..."*

Introducing the Topic

Contributing Productively

Creating Encouraging Ambience

Resolving Conflicts

Reaching an Effective Conclusion



(Contd. ...)

2. Contributing Productively: The participants ought to

- listen attentively to understand the scope of the discussion
- think critically and take pauses for analysis of *reflective-thinking*
- abstain from voicing faulty and poor ideas just for the sake of speaking
- one's knowledge and creativity should be reflected from his/her opinions

3. Creating Encouraging Ambience: Each member of the group is responsible for creating friendly and cooperative atmosphere to encourage optimum participation of the members. Few tips include:

- keeping the discussion vibrant and entertaining
- performing in a less formal and more congenial manner
- showing interest in other participant's views
- arguing not for the sake of merely contradicting other's approach

(Contd. ...)

4. Resolving Conflicts

Take initiative to act as a mediator in case of any altercation

Be respectful and empathetic to the co-participants

Difference in ideas should not give rise to differences among individuals

Adopt an objective outlook

5. Concluding Effectively

The chairperson/evaluator should indicate the winding up of the discussion

The entire discussion should be summed up concisely in 3-4 sentences

Do not add/mention any new idea towards the conclusion



Group Discussion: Requisite Traits

Creative Ideas
&
In-Depth Subject
Knowledge

Efficient Communication
Skills
(Articulation, Listening &
Language)

Leadership
&
Managerial Qualities

Apt use of non-verbals
(Body Language, Tone,
Attitude)

Social & Behavioural Skills
(Politeness, Team Work)

Problem Solving Skills
&
Conflict-Resolution Knacks

Types of Participants in a Group Discussion

DRIVER

An autocrat

Self-righteous attitude

Rejects outright other's opinions

Imposes his own will

Tries to subdue the taciturn

Self-appointed evaluator of others

AMIABLE

Indifferent & Disinterested

Seldom has own views

Taciturn attitude

Abstains from expressing opinions

Tries to conform with majority

Avoids conflict at all costs

DEMOCRAT

Ideal leader

Reigns the driver

Encourages the reticent

Channelizes the discussion in the right path

Contributes productively

Volunteers to resolve conflicts

Leadership: Types

Leadership can be understood as the potential to **influence the members** of a group and to direct the discussion towards a **goal-oriented approach**.

Designated Leader

A person elected or appointed as the leader at the time of group formation

Implied Leader

A group member to whom others defer owing to his rank, expertise, or knowledge

Emergent Leader

A member who assumes the leadership by his assertive personality

"Leadership is the capacity to translate vision into reality."

— Warren G. Bennis

Functions of a Group Leader

PROCEDURAL TASKS

- Distributing the workload
- Keeping the discussion on track
- Analysing and resolving the issues faced by the group members
- Defining criteria for judging the most effective ideas
- Helping the discussion arrive at a conclusive consensus

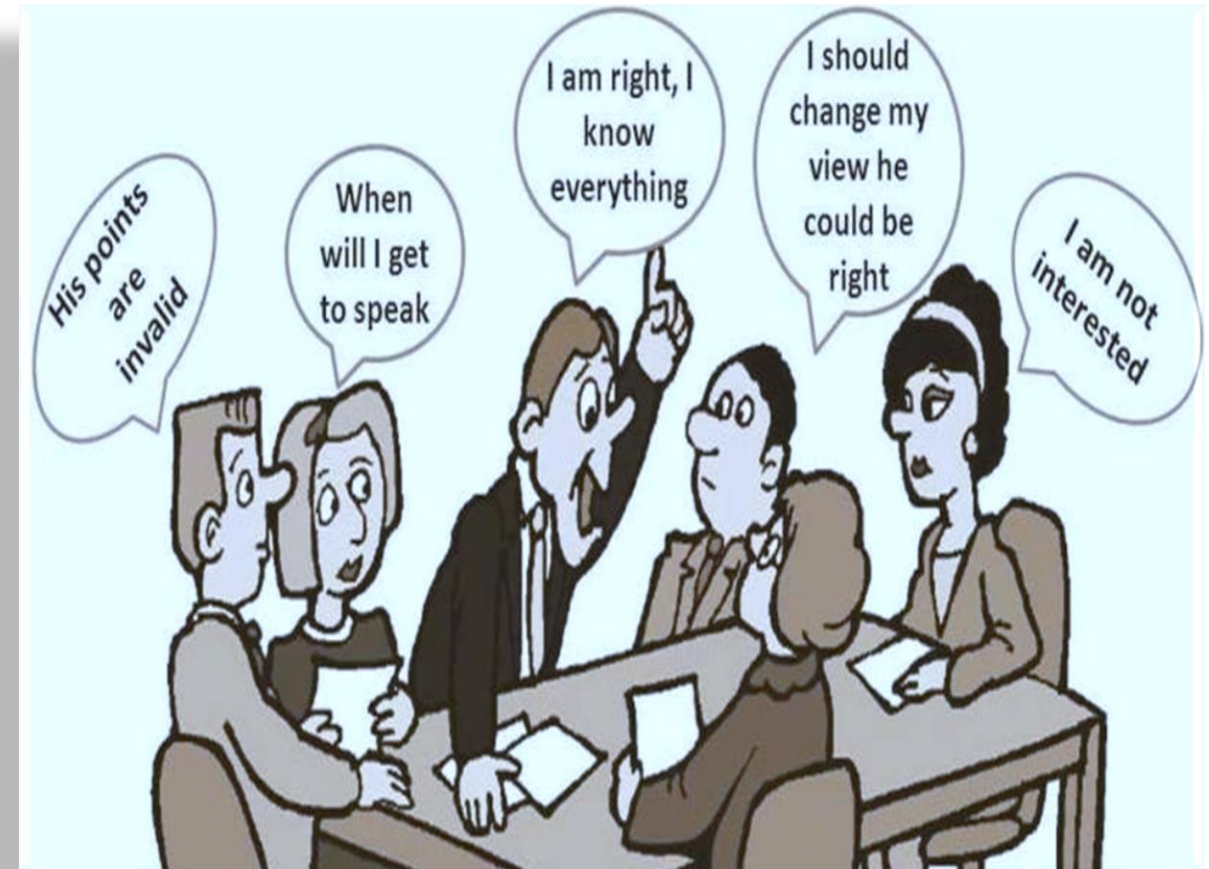
- Deciding the time, venue and agenda of the discussion
- Checking the arrangements (room, chairs, etc.)
- Initiating the discussion
- Taking notes during the meeting
- Preparing aids such as handouts
- Summarizing the progress and the conclusion

FUNCTIONAL TASKS

(Contd. ...)

MAINTENANCE TASKS

- To promote solidarity within the group
- To sustain supportive communication
- To encourage co-operative attitude
- To keep interpersonal tensions at bay
- To encourage participation from all members of the group



THE REFLECTIVE-THINKING METHOD

John Dewey, an American philosopher proposed **the five-step process**, known as **the Reflective – Thinking Method**, for directing discussion in problem-solving groups.

1. **Defining the Problem:** Phrase the problem as a *single, clear, specific, elaborative and unbiased* question.



2. **Analyze the Problem:** Research and gather information upon the scope, causes, and other contributing factors for the question of discussion



3. **Establish criteria:** Establish standards and criteria for an ideal and responsible solution to the question at hand



4. **Generate Potential Solutions:** Brainstorm and come up with the widest possible range of potential solutions



5. **Reach a Consensus:** Evaluate each potential solutions and reach a consensus with regard to the best solution

Group Members: Roles and Responsibilities

❑ Commit to the Goals of the Group:

- Align personal goals with the greater objective of the group
- Do not advance private hidden agendas or ego at the pretext of the group
- Participate with a positive spirit

❑ Fulfil Individual Tasks:

- Divide the workload in a just manner
- Contribute judiciously through your knowledge and expertise on the topic

❑ Abstain from Personal Antagonism:

- Dissent should be aimed at the idea, and not on the person
- An example of dissent on the personal level – “*That’s completely a ridiculous idea. Do you have any idea how much money it would cost us?*”
- The right manner of opposing the idea – “*That sounds a fair solution, but I am afraid it would be highly cost-ineffective.*”

(Contd. ...)

❑ **Encourage Full Participation:**

- Encourage each member to share his/her ideas
- **Draw the reticent members** into the discussion by asking their opinions on the topic
- **Avoid negative comments** like “What a terrible idea!” or “That can never work!”
- **Create goodwill** among the members by appreciating their ideas
- Provide an **amicable milieu** for discussion by listening attentively and allow a **free exchange of ideas**

GREAT MINDS DISCUSS
IDEAS. AVERAGE MINDS
DISCUSS EVENTS.
SMALL MINDS DISCUSS
PEOPLE.

ELEANOR ROOSEVELT

QUOTES^{EVERLASTING}.COM

(Contd. ...)

☐ **Steer Forth the Discussion:**

- ☐ See to it that the discussion proceeds in an orderly manner
- ☐ Do not haste towards the solution without exploring the problem thoroughly
- ☐ Check that the discussion is on track and does not become a stream-of-consciousness exercise.

☐ **Adopt a Disciplined Procedure:**

- ☐ Norms are formulated to attain the desired goals in a systematic manner
- ☐ Follow the prescribed code of discipline for the discussion
- ☐ Do not show aggression to dominate others or push your point

☐ **Shared Leadership:**

- ☐ Leadership tasks are shared at different junctures in a group discussion
- ☐ Be prepared to assume a leadership role whenever required

Conflicts in Group Discussion: Reasons & Resolution

Causes of Conflict

- Incompatible value systems
- Competition for limited resources
- Lack of communication
- Interdependence of tasks
- Unreasonable policies or rules
- Unfair treatment

Resolution of Conflicts

- Clear communication skills
- Active listening
- Empathetic behaviour
- Collaborative work culture
- Unified commitments
- Sound negotiation Strategy
- Reinforce relationships

Using Language Effectively

- ❖ The topic for the discussion may have various dimensions...
- ❖ To my understanding....
- ❖ My views are similar to Mr. X...
- ❖ While the point made by Mr. Y sounds worthy, some clarification would make things clear.
- ❖ The suggestion made by Mr. A seems less practical.
- ❖ I am sorry to interrupt yet...
- ❖ I would appreciate if I am allowed to complete my view point.
- ❖ I think we should also listen to what Mr. X has to say.
- ❖ Perhaps we are distracting from the topic.

Do's and Don'ts in a Group Discussion

Do's

Be at the venue in time and properly dressed.

Listen to the topic/case study carefully.

Organize your thoughts before you speak. Be polite and intervene politely if required.

Be ready to withdraw in case of a better suggestion.

Don'ts

Don't jump to hasty conclusions.

Don't speak fast and take an extreme stance.

Don't repeat wild gestures and avoid shouting .

Don't call names even to an inert participant.

**" Rational discussion is useful only when there is a significant base of shared assumptions."
- Noam Chomsky**

Do's and Don'ts in a Group Discussion

Do's

Be willing to compromise

Extend cooperation with others on their opinions.
Make use of non-verbals.

Have a balanced outlook on both the strengths and the weaknesses

Resolve disagreements by democratic measures like voting

Don'ts

Don't dominate group conversation by aggressive behaviour

Don't deviate the discussion off track by impertinent inputs

Don't continue speaking despite the time being over.

Don't destroy group harmony through unpleasant activities

"If everyone is thinking alike, then someone isn't thinking."

- George S. Patton

“A small group of thoughtful people could change the world. Indeed, it’s the only thing that ever has.”

- Margaret Mead

Thank You!

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